

Mexico

With more than 107 million people, Mexico is the largest Spanish-speaking country in the world and was once the center of the mighty Aztec Empire.

Mexican Wave

The ripple effect of the Mexican Wave is famous and so-named after spectators "waved" at the 1986 World Cup in Mexico.

Mariachi bands

Traditional folk musicians wearing national costume are popular performers throughout Mexico.

Day of the Dead

Mexicans celebrate the Day of the Dead each year, when the souls of the dead are said to visit their loved ones.

Mexico City

The mountains that surround Mexico City trap air pollution, causing a thick layer of smog to blanket the city.

Yucatan

The limestone of the Yucatan peninsula has worn away in some places to form spectacular cenotes (sink holes) and caves.

Guatemala

The largest and most populated of the seven Central American states, Guatemala is mountainous with a fertile plain along the Pacific coast. More than half its people are Amerindians—descendants of the original Maya inhabitants.

Tikal Temple

The Maya built huge pyramid-shaped temples, many of which were only recently rediscovered and restored.

Belize

Once a British colony, Belize is the only English-speaking country in Central America. It is the least populated country in the region and half its land is heavily forested.

Caballeros

Mexican cowboys, known as caballeros locally, are skilled horse riders.

Mexican food

Burritos, guacamole, and chilies are just some of Mexico's world-famous foods.

The world's
your lobster.

Barrier reef

Belize's barrier reef is the second largest in the world, and protects the country's low-lying, swampy coastal plain.

El Salvador

The smallest and most densely populated of the Central American republics, El Salvador lies on the Pacific coast and grows coffee and other crops for export.

Volcanoes

A line of 20 volcanoes runs through the country, providing cheap and plentiful geothermal energy.

Sisal

Sisal plants are grown to yield a stiff fibre that is used to make strong rope and bags for such exports as coffee and cereal.

Nicaragua

The fertile volcanic soil along the Pacific coastline forms the main farming region in Nicaragua. Corn, beans, and sorghum are harvested twice a year while coffee, cotton, and bananas are grown for export.

Lake Nicaragua

Dominating the south of Nicaragua, Lake Nicaragua is the only freshwater lake in the world to contain sea fish, including scary sharks and vigorous swordfish.

Hurricane Mitch

In 1998 Honduras and neighboring Nicaragua suffered huge devastation by Hurricane Mitch.

Bananas

Here, as elsewhere in the region, the main crop is bananas, although coffee, fruit, and flowers are also grown for export.

Costa Rica

One of the richest countries in the region, Costa Rica was the first country in the region to grow coffee, which today is one of its main exports, as well as bananas.

Ecotourism

Costa Rica's forests and wildlife are today protected in reserves and national parks, which attract ecotourists from around the world.

Honduras

Mountainous Honduras has a long coastline on the Caribbean Sea and a short, sheltered outlet to the Pacific. Almost all of its 7.2 million people are Mestizos—mixed Spanish-Amerindian.

This place
is bananas!

Where's that
chameleon?

Cream and
sugar, please.

Explosive
stuff!

It's in
the bag,